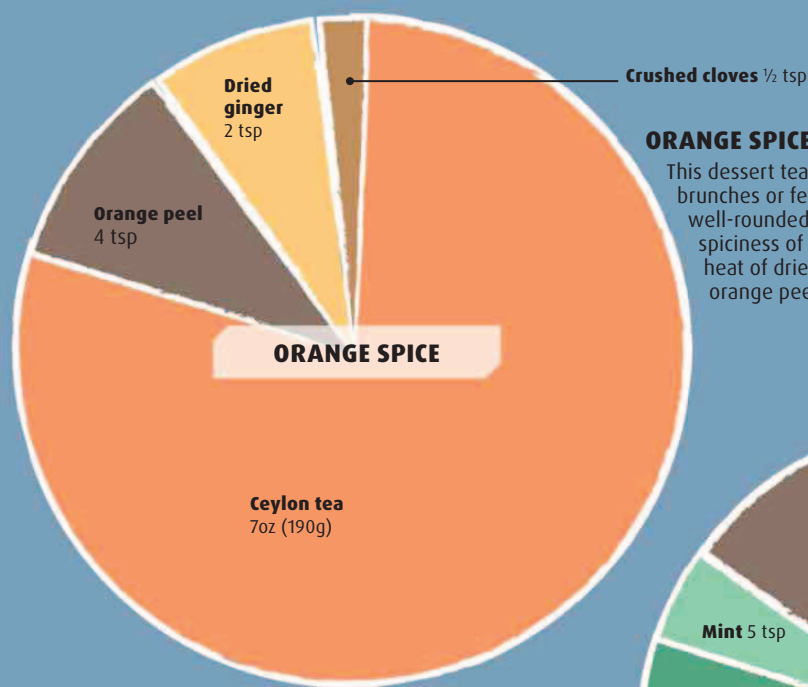


CONTEMPORARY BLENDS

The trend of adding fresh and dried fruit and flowers to tea has been growing in popularity over the last 5 years and there is a growing demand for these blends, characterized by strong, sweet, and fruity flavors. Usually named after pastries and desserts, these blends have become so popular that they now have their own category—"dessert teas." They are also at times known as "gateway teas," as people who may not initially enjoy tea on its own find them palatable. These teas are visually lovely, excellent when served cold, and work well as a liquid ingredient in baking.

It is not necessary to use a high-quality tea in these blends, as the other, more dominant flavors mask the subtleties of the tea leaf. The trick to making a good blend is to use ingredients that get along with one another, and do not fight for attention. A good rule of thumb is that if the ingredients work together as a dessert, they will probably work as a tea when a bold black tea is used as the base, although other types of tea can be used with the right ingredients. Here are some delicious dessert blends to try at home. Infuse them for the same length of time using the same temperature of water as recommended for their base tea.



ORANGE SPICE

This dessert tea is ideal for weekend brunches or festive meals. The bright, well-rounded Ceylon handles the dark spiciness of the crushed cloves and the heat of dried ginger well, while the orange peel sweetens the blend.

CHOCOLATE MINT

Assam is a deep, malty tea that blends well with chocolate. Add either crushed cacao nibs or small chunks of dark chocolate to the tea leaves along with mint (fresh or dried work equally well). The liquor may go cloudy, so it is a good idea to add milk.

